

Accusative case, possessive structure and grammaticalization: reflexives and object pronouns in Hungarian

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Abstract

Hungarian reflexives and 1SG and 2SG object pronouns have a possessive origin, and, together with 1SG and 2SG possessive noun phrases, they exhibit accusative case drop to varying degrees in object positions in a language that is otherwise consistently accusative marking. This paper argues that there is a systematic correlation between the frequency of accusative drop and the degree of grammaticalization in the *possessive domain*: the more grammaticalized possessive structure a reflexive or an object pronoun has, the less likely accusative case is to be spelled out. Following É. Kiss & Mus (2022), accusative drop is analysed as an instance of exaptation, that is, a case of repurposing possessive morphology as accusative marking. The paper presents evidence from diachronic and synchronic corpora to argue that this analysis makes the right predictions both for the historical changes that have taken place in this domain, and for the fine-grained variation in accusative use on reflexives in the synchronic system.

Keywords

accusative case, Hungarian, personal pronoun, reflexive anaphor, complex reflexive, simplex reflexive, possessive noun phrase, corpus study, diachrony, reflexive cycle

1. Introduction¹

Hungarian is an accusative marking language that consistently employs accusative case on direct objects, yet there exist smaller corners of the language where accusative marking is not obligatory. This paper discusses three interrelated cases of accusative drop, i.e., instances of not dressing up an object with the accusative case marker *-t*. Accusative case spellout is largely optional on 1SG and 2SG reflexives that function as objects of the verb, and the case-marked (*magamat* ‘myself.ACC’) and the caseless (*magam* ‘myself’) variants appear to be in free variation (1). In contrast, accusative case use is considered a dialectal phenomenon on 1SG and 2SG personal pronoun objects, dispreferred in standard varieties of the language (2).

- (1) *Regisztrálnom* *kell* *magam(-at)*.
 register.INF.1SG must myself(-ACC)
 ‘I must register myself.’

- (2) *Jól* *hallanak* *téged(°-et)*.
 well hear.3PL you.2SG(-ACC)
 ‘They hear you well.’

¹ The paper uses the following abbreviations in the glosses: 1,2 and 3: first, second and third person, ABL: ablative case, ACC: accusative case, ADJ: adjectivalizing suffix, COND: conditional mood, DAT: dative case, DEFOBJ: definite object conjugation (of the verb), INF: infinitival suffix, IMP: imperative mood, NOM: nominative case, PL: singular, POS: possibility suffix, POSS: possessive marker (on the possessum), PRT: verbal particle, SG: singular. The diacritics used for indicating acceptability judgments are as follows: no marking: fully acceptable, °: varying judgements among speakers (dialectal or idiosyncratic), \$: old fashioned, archaic and/or stylistically marked.

Reflexives and 1SG and 2SG object pronouns have a possessive origin in Hungarian. Possessive noun phrases with 1SG and 2SG possessors also display optional accusative drop:

- (3) a. *Végre felépítettem a ház-am(-at).*
 at.last up.build.PAST.1SG the house-POSS.1SG-ACC
 ‘At last, I have built my house.’
- b. *Fogom a kez-ed(-et).*
 hold.1SG the hand-POSS.2SG-ACC
 ‘I am holding your hand.’

Thus, the three constructions in (1)–(3) each include an object with possessive form and a possessive morphosyntactic structure which has been subject to grammaticalization in the case of reflexives and object pronouns to different degrees.

The primary aim of this paper is to explore the fine-grained distribution of accusative case marking in contemporary Hungarian in the three constructions illustrated in (1)–(3), and to describe the competition between the accusative-marked and the caseless object variants, with particular focus on reflexives. I also argue that the study of diachronic developments in this domain provides a particularly useful vantage point to understand variation in the synchronic system. Recent research into the diachrony of reflexives and personal pronouns has uncovered two historical changes that help us better understand what links the data in (1), (2) and (3).

Both É. Kiss & Mus (2022) and Bassel (forthcoming) argue that complex reflexive anaphors, like many other elements of grammar, enter an intricate diachronic path of development which is *cyclic* in nature. At the initial stage of the cycle, a pronoun is compounded with a relational noun to form a reflexive anaphor. Frequently, like it was the case with the Hungarian reflexive *maga* ‘oneself’, this noun denotes the body or a body part, see, among others, Schladt (2000) or Déchaine & Wiltschko (2017). During the cycle, complex reflexives undergo a gradual grammaticalization process, and assume additional or other functions: intensifiers (*I myself do not agree*), for example, are frequently of reflexive origin. É. Kiss & Mus (2022) identify and describe such a reflexive cycle in Ugric and Samoyedic languages, and they add that this cycle in fact culminates in the creation of a personal pronoun, which may begin to function as a reflexive again and thus start a new round of the cycle. This explains why many pronouns and reflexives show what appears to be the same possessive morphology in these languages: they all exhibit some grammaticalized version of the possessive structure that represents the starting point of the cycle.

É. Kiss & Mus (2022) argue furthermore that possessive morphology may take on the function of object marking in Ugric and Samoyedic languages under certain circumstances, a change they treat as an instance of linguistic *exaptation* in the sense of Lass (1990) or Haiman (2017). Having lost its original possessive function, possessive morphology is repurposed as an object marking device. What I claim in this paper is that this process of *exaptation* may also be cyclic in nature, and it is still in progress in the empirical domain under study. Accusative case thus serves as a diagnostic for the amount of possessive structure that is available: the more this structure is grammaticalized, the less likely it will show accusative marking. I present both diachronic and synchronic evidence to substantiate this claim. I show that accusative case use has been on the decline across these constructions ever since a peak in the Old Hungarian period, but reflexives and object pronouns have been losing their accusative case at faster pace than possessive noun phrases. This is so because their gradually bleached possessive structure has been increasingly repurposed as object marking. Close attention to micro-variation in the spellout of accusative case on different types of reflexives in contemporary Hungarian reveals furthermore that this, in fact, is not an instance of free variation: the more referential the reflexive is, the more likely native speakers are to use accusative case on reflexive objects. In

turn, these referential readings are available for the reflexive if it has a less grammaticalized possessive structure.

The fundamental goal of this paper is thus threefold. First, I give a systematic overview of the surface possessive properties of two types of reflexives and first and second person object pronouns in Hungarian, arguing that a significant amount of variation is observable among these items in the synchronic system in this respect. Second, I argue that accusative drop in this domain has been on the rise since the Old Hungarian period, and accusative case use shows a more intricate distribution in the synchronic system than usually assumed. Third, I claim that there is a systematic correlation between the frequency of accusative drop and the degree of grammaticalization in the *possessive domain*: the more grammaticalized possessive structure a reflexive or an object pronoun has, the less likely accusative case is to be spelled out.

Most of the data I report here come from various historical or synchronic corpora of Hungarian. The detailed results of the corpus surveys are given in a separate Appendix. Throughout the paper, I focus on 1SG and 2SG forms, because these represent the part of the respective paradigms where the grammatical effects we discuss are the strongest.

The structure of the paper is as follows. Section 2 offers a discussion of the possessive morphosyntactic traits of reflexives and object pronouns in contemporary Hungarian. Sections 3 and 4 investigate accusative case use on reflexives and pronouns as compared to possessive noun phrases. Section 3 presents the results of the corpus surveys targeting 1SG and 2SG possessive noun phrase objects, object pronouns, and the reflexives *magam* ‘myself’ and *magad* ‘yourself’ used as objects of the verb. I show that the frequency of accusative case use has been decreasing in historical terms within this domain, and that object pronouns and reflexives are ahead of possessives in this change. Section 4 discusses the distribution of accusative case on 1SG and 2SG reflexives in contemporary Hungarian. This section contrasts the primary argument reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ and the more complex reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’ in this respect, and it identifies pertinent variation among two distinct uses of the primary reflexive. I present corpus evidence to substantiate the claim that accusative case is more likely on reflexives in the case of exempt or referential uses, and I argue that these uses come with a more active possessive structure. Section 5 offers a summary and an outlook.

2. On the possessive traits of reflexives and object pronouns

2.1 An overview of the data

The possessor bears no overt case in the basic Hungarian possessive construction, and pronominal possessors are cross-referenced by agreement morphology on the possessum.² The possessor itself is normally *pro*-dropped (4a), unless it bears a discourse function (4b).

- (4) a. *Felvettem az ing-em-et.*
 PRT.took.1SG the shirt-POSS.1SG-ACC
 ‘I put on my shirt.’
 b. *Miért az ÉN ing-em-et vetted fel?*
 why the I shirt-POSS.1SG-ACC took.2SG PRT
 ‘Why did you put on MY shirt?’

² Whether unmarked possessors bear nominative case or have no case is an issue orthogonal to our discussion, together with a deeper exploration of the morphology and syntax of Hungarian possessive constructions. I focus on what we may regard as surface possessive traits, and refer the reader to Szabolcsi (1994), Laczkó (1995), Bartos (1999), É. Kiss (2002), den Dikken (2006), Rákosi (2020) and Dékány (2021) for in-depth discussions and references.

The personal pronoun possessor is preceded by the definite article in (4), which marks the left edge of the possessive noun phrase in both examples.

Table 1 contains the possessive paradigm of the noun head *hal* ‘fish’, as well as the paradigm of object pronouns and reflexives. The paradigm of (nominative) subject pronouns is also included for comparison.

	SUBJECT PRONOUNS	OBJECT PRONOUNS	OBJECT REFLEXIVE	OBJECT POSSESSIVES: HAL ‘FISH’
1SG	<i>én</i> I	<i>engem</i> -(%-et) me-ACC	<i>magam</i> -(at) myself-ACC	<i>halam</i> -(at) fish.POSS.1SG-ACC
2SG	<i>te</i> you.SG	<i>téged</i> -(%-et) you.SG-ACC	<i>magad</i> -(at) yourself-ACC	<i>halad</i> -(at) fish.POSS.2SG-ACC
3SG	<i>ő</i> (s)he	<i>ő-t</i> (s)he-ACC	<i>magá-t</i> oneself-ACC	<i>halá-t</i> fish.POSS.3SG-ACC
1PL	<i>mi</i> we	<i>mink-et</i> us-ACC	<i>magunk</i> -%(-at) ourselves-ACC	<i>halunk</i> -%(-at) fish.POSS.1PL-ACC
2PL	<i>ti</i> you.PL	<i>titek-et</i> you.PL-ACC	<i>magatok</i> -%(-at) yourselves-ACC	<i>halatok</i> -%(-at) fish.POSS.2PL-ACC
3PL	<i>ők</i> they	<i>ők-et</i> they-ACC	<i>maguk</i> - [§] (-at) themselves-ACC	<i>haluk</i> - [§] (-at) fish.POSS.3PL-ACC

Table 1. Subject pronouns and object pronouns, reflexives and possessives in Hungarian

Accusative case (-Vt) is added on top of the possessive morphology, and it shows a complex distributional pattern across the paradigms in Table 1. The cells marked grey are those paradigmatic positions where accusative drop is prevalent: this is the zone that is the target of our investigation in this paper.

In the paradigm of object personal pronouns, accusative drop is only attested in 1SG and 2SG, where the accusative-marked variant has been described as dialectal (see É. Kiss 2020: 7, Dékány 2018: 395). For first and second person reflexives and possessive noun phrases, much of the pertinent literature describes the accusative-marked and the caseless variants as essentially being in free variation (see É. Kiss 2020: 7, Dékány 2018: 395 on possessive noun phrases, and Keszler 2000: 163 on reflexives). In fact, accusative drop is less frequent on the plural of reflexives and possessive noun phrases, and omission of the accusative marker is sometimes described as a marked phenomenon in this part of the paradigm (see Grétsy & Kovalovszky 1985 II: 556). Accusative case is obligatory on 3PL forms for many, but not for all speakers (with younger generations being slightly more permissive). The reason why we focus on 1SG and 2SG forms in this paper is that this is the domain where the effects that we study here emerge consistently for all speakers in standard Hungarian.

The morphological parallels between reflexives and possessive noun phrases are evident if we compare the two respective columns of Table 1. The nominal stem of the reflexive, *mag*, means ‘core’ or ‘seed’ in contemporary Hungarian, and it may have had the meaning ‘body’ in Proto-Hungarian.³ This reflexive serves as the primary argument reflexive in Hungarian (henceforth: *primary reflexive*), and it has a more complex variant *önmagam* ‘myself’. The morpheme *ön-* in *önmagam* was in use as a reflexive intensifier in the Old Hungarian period (roughly equivalent to English *own*), and it developed into a nominal prefix meaning ‘self’ by

³ See Kertész (1911) for an early comprehensive discussion of this issue.

the late 18th century (see the pertinent entries in Gerstner ed. 2011–2025). Modulo this prefix, the paradigm of *önmagam* is identical to that of *magam*.

Though the *mag*-stem has come to be bleached completely, contemporary native speakers may still have intuitions concerning the structural analogy between *önmagamat* ‘myself.ACC’ in (5a) and *önuralmamat* ‘my self-control.ACC’ (5b).

- (5) a. *Ön-magam-at* *vádoltam*.
 self-myself-ACC blamed.1SG
 ‘I was blaming myself.’
 b. *Elvesztettem az ön-uralmam-at*.
 PRT.lost1SG the self-control.POSS.1SG-ACC
 ‘I lost my self-control.’

Önmagam ‘myself’ is not only more complex than the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’, it is also historically more recent.⁴ Given its extra nominal morphology (the *ön*- prefix) and its relatively late appearance, *önmagam* is expected to be less grammaticalized, i.e., show more active possessive properties in its syntax, than the primary reflexive *magam*. I argue in the next subsection that this is indeed the case.

In contrast, the 1SG and 2SG object pronouns *engem* ‘me’ and *téged* ‘you’ do not display any properties in standard Hungarian that could be associated with the presence of a syntactically active possessive structure. The primary reason why some of the pertinent literature treats these two object pronouns as possessive is their apparent morphological complexity (see den Dikken 2004: 466–467, den Dikken 2006: 14, Dékány 2018: 395, as well as É. Kiss & Mus 2022: 50 for discussion). Compare the object pronouns on the right with the respective possessive noun phrases on the left.

- (6) a. *az én ing-em* ~ *en-g-em*
 the I shirt-POSS.1SG I-g-POSS.1SG
 ‘my shirt’ ‘me’
 b. *a te ing-ed* ~ *té-g-ed*
 the you shirt-POSS.2SG you-g-POSS.2SG
 ‘your shirt’ ‘you’

The possessive agreement morphology is the same on the lexical possessum and on the pronouns (-*em*, -*ed*). If we assume that the *g*-element in the middle of the pronouns is the residue of the *mag*-stem that we find in reflexives, the preceding material can be regarded as an allomorphic variant of the pronominal possessor in the possessive noun phrase on the left (*én~en*, *te~té*). But even if the form of these two object pronouns bears witness to their possessive origin, this structure has been so highly grammaticalized that it displays no obvious possessive syntactic properties in the synchronic system.⁵

⁴ The first occurrence of *önmaga* ‘oneself’ is from the late 14th century, but *maga* ‘oneself’ is present already in the earliest Hungarian texts from the 12th century onwards.

⁵ First and second person object pronouns might show morphosyntactic properties in non-standard varieties of Hungarian which suggest that at least some contemporary native speakers assign a more active possessive structure to them. Since these are highly non-standard forms, I do not include them in the current paper (but see Rákosi in prep. for data and discussion).

2.2 The possessive features of reflexives

The overall syntactic distribution of the two reflexives *magam* and *önmagam* ‘myself’ is remarkably similar to that of noun phrases, and, in particular, their syntax aligns with the external syntax of possessive noun phrases in several respects.⁶ One line of argument for the possessive analysis of reflexives comes from the study of object agreement patterns. First and second person object pronouns require the default form of a finite transitive verb, which is referenced as the *subjective* or *indefinite* conjugation in Hungarian grammars (7b). This is the form of the verb that is used if the object is indefinite, or if there is no object (7a).

- (7) a. *Flóra lát (egy lány-t).*
 Flóra see.3SG a girl-ACC.
 ‘Flóra can see (a girl).’
 b. *Flóra lát engem(%-et) / téged(%-et).*
 Flóra see.3SG me-ACC / you-ACC
 ‘Flóra sees me/you.’

Reflexives, however, require the *objective* or *definite conjugation* (8b–c), in which they pattern with third person object pronouns, definite noun phrases, and possessive noun phrases (8a).⁷

- (8) a. *Flóra lát-ja a lány-t / anyád(-at) / őt.*
 Flóra see-DEFOBJ.3SG the girl-ACC mother.POSS.2SG-ACC her
 ‘Flóra sees the girl/your mother/her.’
 b. *Flóra lát-ja magát / önmagát.*
 Flóra see-DEFOBJ.3SG herself-ACC herself-ACC
 ‘Flóra sees herself.’
 c. *Lát-om magam(-at) / önmagam(-at)*
 see-DEFOBJ.1SG myself-ACC myself-ACC
 ‘I see myself.’

Each member of the reflexive paradigm, including 1SG and 2SG reflexives, elicits the objective conjugation on the verb, unlike 1SG and 2SG object pronouns. This fact may be explained by pointing out the analogy between reflexives and possessive noun phrases, given that possessive noun phrases, by default, trigger the objective conjugation. If we assume that reflexives still have a syntactically active possessive shell in Hungarian, then they trigger the objective conjugation because they are DP’s (Bartos 1999: 104), or because they are third person (Bárány 2015: 39), all through the paradigm. Thus, it is their possessive structure that makes 1SG and 2SG reflexives crucially different from 1SG and 2SG personal pronouns in this respect.

There are, however, two important gaps in the syntactic distribution of *magam* ‘myself’ that make the primary reflexive crucially different both from *önmagam* ‘myself’ and from (possessive) noun phrases. First, each member of the paradigm of *önmagam* triggers 3SG agreement on potential agreement targets, but the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ is subject to the *Anaphor Agreement Effect*, banning it from positions construed with agreement (see Rákosi 2019 and 2022 for detailed discussion). As a consequence, only *önmagam* can be the

⁶ Disregarding, naturally, Binding Theoretic effects that further constrain this distribution. I use the 1SG forms as the citation forms of reflexives for the whole of the respective paradigms from now on in this paper.

⁷ Hungarian lacks grammatical gender. I translate the examples into English using whichever gender feature is more appropriate in the given context.

subject of a finite clause, *magam* cannot. Backward binding configurations with an object or a dative experiencer antecedent are the typical syntactic contexts where this kind of anaphora is licensed (see É. Kiss 2000: 35–40, Rákosi 2015). In example (9), the object experiencer *engem* ‘me’ antecedes the VP-internal subject reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’.

- (9) *Nem csak engem ijeszt meg *(ön-)magam.*
 not only me frighten.3SG PRT self-myself.NOM
 ‘It is not only me who is frightened by myself.’ (lit.: ‘*Myself frightens not only me.’)

Second, *magam* cannot be used predicatively, whereas *önmagam* can. Consider the two examples in (10), in which the reflexive acts as a predicative complement in an identity statement:

- (10) a. *Itt újra *(ön-)magam vagyok.*
 here again self-myself am
 ‘Here I am myself again.’ (...and not somebody else)
 b. *Nem tudok *(ön-)magam lenni, mindig szerepet kell játszanom.*
 not can.1SG self-myself be.INF always role.ACC must play.INF.1SG
 ‘I cannot be myself; I must always play a role.’

The primary reflexive *magam* is ungrammatical in this role in contemporary Hungarian.⁸

In general, *önmagam* licenses referential readings in appropriate contexts, typically when the antecedent and the reflexive are expected to be referentially distinct (see Rákosi 2011, 2019 for more on this). (11a) represents one such context: one can normally be a stranger to others, not to the self. Note that the primary reflexive *magam* is degraded in this context. By contrast, *önmagam* is ungrammatical as the object of an intrinsically reflexive predicate, and *magam(-at)* is the obligatory choice here (11b).

- (11) a. *Idegen voltam ??(ön-)magam-nak.*
 stranger was.1SG self-myself-DAT
 ‘I was a stranger to myself.’
 b. *Kihúztam (*ön-)magam(-at).*
 out.drew.1SG self-myself-ACC
 ‘I drew myself up.’

Given that *önmagam* is intrinsically geared towards referential uses, it is not surprising that it cannot be used in (11b), since this verbal predicate does not allow for an object argument that is referentially distinct from the subject.

Thus, the grammatical behaviour of *önmagam* ‘myself’ is fully consistent with a possessive analysis, that is, an analysis which assumes that this reflexive may still have an active possessive structure at the synchronic stage of the language. In fact, *önmagam* even licenses the construction of a full-fledged possessive phrase around it, including adjectival modifiers and an overt possessor. In this case, the DP structure headed by the anaphor as the possessum can function as a subject of any verb, as example (12) illustrates:

⁸ The primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ is acceptable in (10a) and (10b) as a reflexive intensifier with the meaning ‘alone’ (as in *I cannot do it myself*).

- (12) *Ha megkérdezné tőlem [DP az én akkori *(ön-)magam], hogy ...*
 if PRT.ask.COND.3SG ABL.1SG the I then.ADJ self-myself.NOM that
 ‘If my then-self asked me whether ...’

These striking possessive features characterize the whole paradigm of *önmagam*, and they can surface in any of its syntactic functions, including structures where the reflexive is an object.

In contrast, the primary reflexive *magam* cannot serve as the head of an extended possessive noun phrase in contemporary Hungarian, and it is therefore ungrammatical in (12). It is noteworthy nevertheless that *magam* used to be different, and it could take dependents typical of a possessive noun phrase even as late as the early 20th century. In (13a), *magam* ‘myself’ takes the personal pronoun *én* ‘I’ acting as its structural possessor, and the resulting complex form is an emphatic, stressed variant of the reflexive. Such emphatic reflexives were especially common in the Old Hungarian period, that is, from the first coherent Hungarian texts starting to appear in the late 12th century till the early 16th century (see Kertész 1911). To observe the analogy with possessive noun phrases, compare (13a) with the PP that takes a possessive noun phrase including an overt pronoun possessor in (13b).

- (13) a. Hungarian Historical Corpus (1914, doc id. 9379015)
...én-magam előtt is pirulnom kellett miattuk.
 I-myself before too blush.INF.1SG had.to because.of.3PL
 ‘I had to blush in front of me, too, because of them.’
 b. *az én hal-am előtt*
 the I fish-POSS.1SG before
 ‘in front of my fish’

(14) is an example where the reflexive takes a modifying adjective.

- (14) Hungarian Historical Corpus (1894, doc id. 8349004)
Ezek közül kettőt veszek ki. Rózát és csekély magam-at,
 these among.from two.ACC take.1SG out Róza.ACC and petty myself-ACC
 ‘I exclude two from these. Róza and my petty self, ...’

Such examples, just like (13a), have a marked status and an archaic flavour for contemporary native speakers, indicating that *magam* ‘myself’ has reached a stage during its grammaticalization where its original possessive structure has been reduced to the extent that the sort of overt structure building that (12) illustrates is not available anymore.

Thus, *magam* ‘myself’ is a highly grammaticalized reflexive. Its nominal stem, *mag-*, has been completely bleached. It has retained a *prima facie* possessive morphology, and while its overall syntactic distribution approximates that of a genuine possessive noun phrase, its syntax is also more constrained. It cannot, for example, be a finite subject or a predicative complement – unlike the more complex reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’, which is not subject to such constraints. *Önmagam* can still act as the head of a richly decorated possessive noun phrase, a potential which *magam* has lost during its history. In sum, while *önmagam* shows strong possessive features in contemporary Hungarian, the primary reflexive *magam* has left most of its possessive past behind. It is reasonable to conclude that *önmagam* appeared in the late Old Hungarian period because there was a need for a more complex and more referential reflexive with a more active possessive structure when the primary reflexive *magam* had already progressed along its grammaticalization path. The medieval birth of *önmagam* represents a case of *reinforcement* in the sense of Lehmann (2015 [1982]: 24–25, 52), a process during which an

element that has been “weakened through grammaticalization” takes on extra morphology to “compensate for decay”.

2.3 One note on the diachronic development of reflexives and object pronouns

We have just seen that *önmagam* ‘myself’ is a relative latecomer in historical terms, as compared to the older form *magam* ‘myself’. It is less obvious what the historical relation between the primary reflexive and the 1SG and 2SG object pronouns *engem* ‘me’ and *téged* ‘you’ is. 1SG and 2SG object pronouns may have developed via further grammaticalization of the reflexive *magam*, phonologically reducing the *mag-* stem to *-g-* (see section 2.1). In fact, this is the expected diachrony within the Reflexive Cycle that É. Kiss & Mus (2022) propose:

(15) The Reflexive Cycle of É. Kiss & Mus (2022)

reflexives > intensifiers > intensive pronouns > neutral pronouns > new reflexives

But the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ and its assumed derivative, *engem* ‘me’ coexist in contemporary Hungarian. This may be the result of two consecutive rounds of the cycle, the first of which produced eventually the object pronouns, and the second the (new) reflexive.⁹ Another possibility is that both share the same historical source, but the reflexive has been lagging behind the object pronouns in grammaticalization due perhaps to system pressures: reflexive anaphors are frequently complex.¹⁰

One potential argument for the same source (i.e., single cycle) approach to the history of contemporary object pronouns and reflexives comes from sporadic object agreement data in Old Hungarian which do not appear to be well-behaving at first. As mentioned in 2.2 above, reflexive objects trigger the object conjugation, but 1SG and 2SG object pronouns require the default form of the verb (*subjective conjugation*). This is also true of Old Hungarian data, but we may also occasionally find some complex reflexives, containing an emphatic form of the relevant pronominal possessor, which do not trigger the objective conjugation. Note that the apparent reflexive does not have a more prominent local antecedent in these examples.

(16) Jókai Codex, 137/22 (1370/1440)

<i>mert</i>	<i>nem</i>	<i>hyuot</i>	<i>ten magadot</i>	<i>te erted</i>
mert	nem	hívott	ten-magad-ot	te-ért-ed
because	not	call.PAST.3SG	you-yourself-ACC	you-for-2SG
‘because he did not call you for yourself’				

(17) München Codex, 103va/Jn_17/3 (1466)

<i>hog</i>	<i>tenmagadat</i>	<i>èfmèzien^c</i>	<i>a3</i>	<i>iga3</i>	<i>iftènn^c</i>
hogy	ten-magad-at	ismerjenek	az	igaz	istennek
that	you-yourself-ACC	know.IMP.3PL	the	true	god.DAT
‘that they might know thee the true God’					

⁹ É. Kiss & Mus (2022) argue that at least three rounds of renewal can be identified in Tundra Nenets. Such processes of renewal may have happened in Hungarian, too, albeit partially in the period which is undocumented.

¹⁰ It is a recurrent idea in the syntactic literature on reflexives that reflexive anaphors need a protective shell that allows the pronominal element inside (the possessor in the case of body-part anaphors) to survive in configurations where a local antecedent is present (see, among others, Reuland 2001, 2011, Preminger 2019, and Bassel 2024 for alternative proposals elaborating on this approach to anaphora). This protective layer is the grammaticalized, but syntactically active, possessive DP projection on many reflexive anaphors.

Thus, these reflexives behave here exactly like 2SG object pronouns, a possibility which is not available in contemporary Hungarian. One plausible account may then go as follows. Let us suppose that the cycle started with a strongly possessive reflexive form with a spelled-out pronominal possessor: *te(n)-mag-ad(-at)* ‘you-*mag*-POSS.2SG-ACC’. This had been gradually (and mostly) reduced by the end of the Old Hungarian period to the current primary reflexive: *magad(-at)* ‘yourself-ACC’. In parallel, it had already been developing into an even more reduced object pronoun, *té-g-ed(-et)* ‘you-*g*-POSS.2SG-ACC’, which coexisted for a while with the pronominal use of the original reflexive form *te(n)magadat*.¹¹ This latter variety largely disappeared by the end of the Old Hungarian period, leaving us with a stage close to the current system. The same holds of the 1SG forms.

Given the lack of available historical data from the early Old Hungarian period and before, it is difficult to ascertain what exactly happened, but the above is one possible course of events. What is important for our forthcoming study of the distribution of accusative case is that today 1SG and 2SG object pronouns are at the end of the grammaticalization process, not showing any active possessive traits in their syntax. These object pronouns co-exist in the synchronic state of the language with the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ and the complex reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’, which are equipped with less grammaticalized possessive structures and which thus represent earlier stages of the cycle in (15). Thus, regarding the empirical coverage of the Reflexive Cycle as one functional domain, we see an instance of layering in the current system, wherein earlier stages are not discarded but co-exist with new ones (see Hopper 1991).

3. The decline of accusative case use in the possessive domain: A corpus study

3.1 Introduction

I repeat (1)–(3) as (18) to illustrate the phenomenon of *accusative drop* that we study here. As we have seen, the consensual judgement in the literature is that accusative case spellout is only a dialectal option on 1SG and 2SG object pronouns in contemporary Hungarian (18a). Accusative drop is a general alternative on 1SG and 2SG reflexives and possessive noun phrases, the caseless and the case-marked varieties are considered to be in free variation.

- (18) a. *Jól hallanak téged(°-et).*
 well hear.3PL you(-ACC)
 ‘They hear you well.’
- b. *Regisztrálnom kell magam(-at).*
 register.INF.1SG must myself(-ACC)
 ‘I must register myself.’
- c. *Végre felépítettem a ház-am(-at).*
 at.last up.build.PAST.1SG the house-POSS.1SG-ACC
 ‘At last, I have built my house.’

The pertinent literature offers no comments on accusative case use on *önmagam* in object positions, but accusative drop is possible on this type of reflexive, too.

What requires explanation is why this phenomenon of accusative drop is so characteristic of 1SG and 2SG possessive environments only, and why, in the first place, the phenomenon of accusative drop exists. É. Kiss (2013, 2017, 2020) and É. Kiss & Mus (2022) seek to answer these questions with reference to diachronic developments within the Uralic languages, and,

¹¹ Changes in vowel quality in the post-stem part follow from the harmonizing nature of Hungarian.

more specifically, within the Ugric branch that includes Hungarian. In É. Kiss’s reconstruction, Proto-Ugric had a system of object marking via object agreement with the verb and accusative case that was associated with topics only. In turn, topic selection was governed by the *Inverse Topicality Constraint*, “forbidding that the structurally less prominent secondary topic be more prominent than the primary topic in the topicality hierarchy ‘1st person/2nd person > 3rd person’” (É. Kiss 2020: 10).¹² This, in essence, blocks a configuration in which, for example, a 1SG object pronoun is topicalized in the presence of a third person subject. Such objects were typically focussed constituents, which did not agree with the verb, and which did not receive accusative case. Because focal pronouns are usually strong, it is not by accident that it is exactly these pronouns that display a possessive structure, which is characteristic of the Reflexive Cycle in the Uralic languages. As their possessive structure was gradually reduced, the possessive morphology on these pronouns was reinterpreted as object marking in what É. Kiss & Mus (2022) describe as a process of *exaptation*. In a language system where accusative marking has come to be widespread, such *functional repurposing* is not a surprising move (see Haiman 2017 for a discussion of the linguistic understanding of exaptation).

É. Kiss thus claims that the synchronic system of Hungarian is essentially a fossilized remnant of this earlier system. In her approach, 1SG and 2SG object pronouns bear no accusative case because they never had any: their possessive shell was repurposed as accusative morphology. The dialectal use of accusative case on these pronouns is an innovation. In first and second person, possessive noun phrases and reflexives with a possessive structure can drop their accusative by analogy to object pronouns.

The diachronic data that I report on in this section adds a somewhat unexpected twist to this account. As I show, accusative case use in the possessive domain represented by the constructions in (18) was more frequent in Old Hungarian than it is now, and it has been declining in frequency ever since. I report on corpus data that I have gathered from historical and synchronic corpora of Hungarian to understand the nature of variation in accusative case spellout in more depth. The aim is to confirm the hypothesis that the more grammaticalized possessive structure an element has, the more likely it is to occur without an overt accusative marker, since possessive morphology is more likely to have undergone exaptation as an object marking device. The corpus query targeted 1SG and 2SG object pronouns, primary reflexives, and possessive noun phrases. I refer to this data set in short as *the possessive domain*.

The corpora that I have queried are listed in Table 3.

CORPUS NAME	ACRONYM	SIZE (MILLION WORDS)	TIMESPAN (CENTURIES)
<i>Old Hungarian Corpus</i>	OHC	3.2	12th-17th
<i>Old and Middle Hungarian Corpus of Informal Language Use</i>	OMHC	1.112	15th-18th
<i>Corpus of Middle Hungarian Memoires and Dramas</i>	CMH	0.2	16th-18th
<i>Hungarian Historical Corpus</i>	HHC	30	18th-21st
<i>Hungarian Gigaword Corpus</i>	HGC	1.040	20th-21st

Table 3. The corpora used in the corpus study

¹² É. Kiss (2013: 8) postulates the following, partially unordered hierarchy for Hungarian: 1SG > 1PL, 2SG, 2PL > 3SG, 3PL.

The references to these corpora, as well as the raw frequency data, are added in a separate Appendix, and the main text presents a comparative overview of the search results. The corpora are partially overlapping in their timespan, and they also substantially differ in size. Nevertheless, together they provide a reliable representation of historical developments in Hungarian.

In the case of 1SG and 2SG object pronouns, both the caseless variety and the one marked with accusative case serve the unique function of being an object. The uncase-marked form of possessives and reflexives, however, is multifunctional and is therefore syntactically ambiguous. Besides being the object of the verb, these forms can function as possessors themselves, or as complements of one class of postpositions. Uncase-marked possessive noun phrases can also be subjects or vocatives, and reflexives can act as intensifier associates of subjects. For this reason, I have manually annotated data containing uncase-marked possessives and reflexives. In the case of the Hungarian Historical Corpus and the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus, manual annotation required the selection of subcorpora of manageable sizes. The selection procedure is described in the Appendix.¹³

The diagrams in the forthcoming subsections illustrate the relative frequency of accusative marking within the possessive domain, i.e., the proportion of accusative-marked forms among all the object uses of the given item.

3.2 1SG and 2SG object pronouns: *engem(-et)* and *téged(-et)*

The results of the queries on object pronouns are summarized in Figure 1.

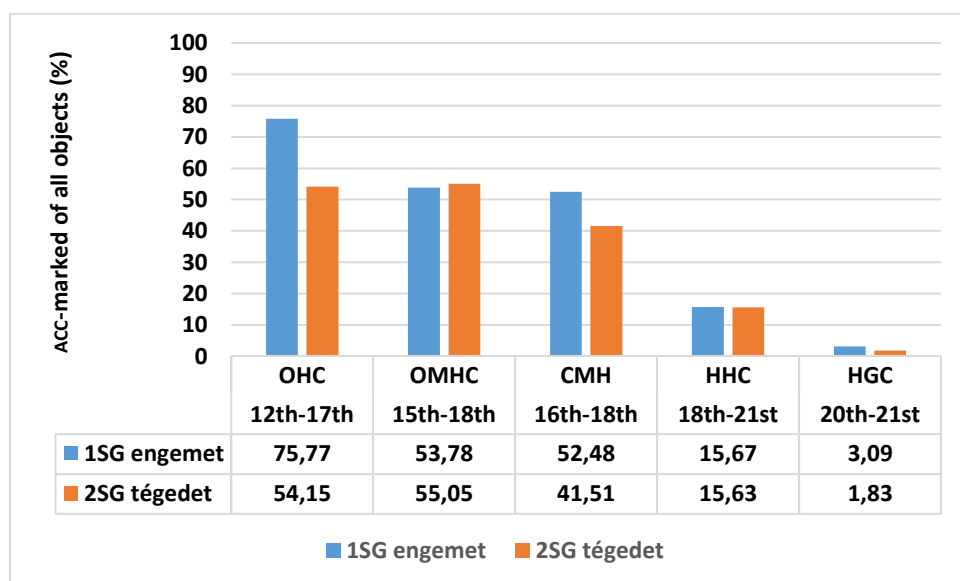


Figure 1. The relative frequency of ACC-marked forms among all 1SG and 2SG object pronouns in 5 corpora

What we see is that until the Modern Hungarian period (i.e., before the end of the 18th century), the caseless and the case-marked varieties were more or less equally frequent, which confirms the descriptions historical grammars provide (see, for example, D. Máta 1999). The following

¹³ The size of the data sets behind the frequency figures may vary, depending on the size of the corpus studied (see the Appendix for details). For the purposes of this paper, I have made the (simplifying) assumption that the proportional frequencies are reliably and directly comparable figures even if the data sets differ in size.

near-minimal pair includes a caseless (19a) and a case-marked (19b) 1SG object pronoun from the same early 16th century text.

(19) a. Czech Codex, 134 - 1/92803 (1513)

Mýndõn gonoztwl zabadoh engõm vram.
 minden gonosztól szabadíts engem Uram
 every evil.from free.IMP.2SG me lord.POSS.1SG
 ‘Deliver me from all evil, my lord.’

b. Czech Codex, 7 - 1/84999 (1513)

zabadoh engõmeth mýndõn ... ellensegõmtwl.
 szabadíts engem-et minden ... ellenségemtől
 free.IMP.2SG me-ACC every enemy.POSS.1SG.from
 ‘Deliver me from all my enemies.’

A slow decline in accusative case use is observable as a trend through the ages, which becomes more pronounced in Modern Hungarian and it culminates in the complete disappearance of *engem-et* ‘me-ACC’ and *téged-et* ‘you-ACC’ from the vocabulary of younger generations of native speakers today.

This also means that the accusative-marked 1SG and 2SG object pronouns may be felt to be dialectal because they are in fact archaic, and countryside dialects are often regarded as storehouses of archaic forms of the language. In fact, they need not be: younger generations consistently prefer the uncase-marked form across dialects. É. Kiss (2000: fn. 7) suggests that the accusative-marked variety is an innovative form in some dialects, but what our data show is that historical change has most probably happened in the other direction.

Finally, I only note that on the whole, the 1SG pronoun appears to be slightly more accusative preferring than the 2SG pronoun, a tendency which is noticeable with reflexives and possessive noun phrases, too, as we will see below. Further research is needed to understand if this person split is real and strong enough to merit attention, but I leave this issue open in this paper.

3.3 1SG and 2SG object reflexives: *magam(-at)* and *magad(-at)*

Figure 2 presents the results of the corpus searches targeting the primary reflexive.

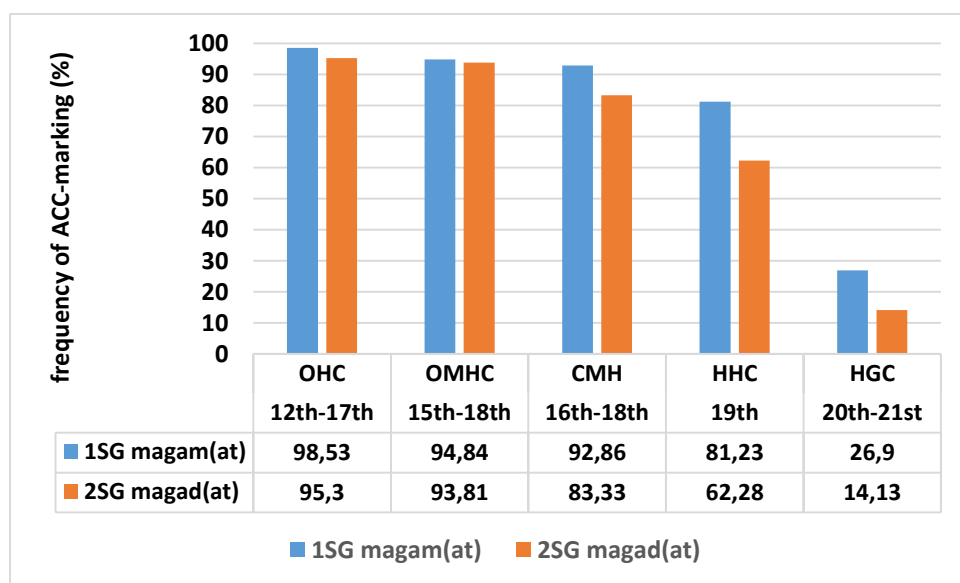


Figure 2. The relative frequency of ACC-marked forms

among 1SG and 2SG object reflexives in 5 corpora

The Old Hungarian period is characterized by a clear dominance of the case-marked reflexive, and the caseless variant slowly starts to gain momentum in the Middle Hungarian period (16th–18th century). In that age, a typical occurrence of object *magam* ‘myself’ or *magad* ‘yourself’ is the object argument of an intrinsically reflexive predicate. (20) is an early 18th century example:

- (20) *Emészttem magam, de haszontalan.* (OMHC, 1709)
 digest.1SG myself but futilely
 ‘I worry myself to death, but to no avail.’

Thus, the caseless variety starts to spread first in constructions where the reflexive is a syntactic formative void of its usual semantic contribution (see Reuland 2006: 267–268 for pertinent discussion). The disappearance of accusative case on objects of intrinsically reflexive verbs has become a more pronounced trend in contemporary Hungarian, as we will see in Section 4.

There is a noticeable drop in the frequency of the accusative-marked form in Modern Hungarian. In fact, accusative case on reflexives appears to be fast disappearing from standard colloquial Hungarian.¹⁴ The entry of the reflexive *maga* ‘oneself’ in the Explanatory Dictionary of Hungarian (Bárczi & Országh 1959–1962) contains a remark that corroborates this: the caseless forms are described there as belonging to *elaborate* or *poetic* registers. The tide seems to have turned for accusative case since then, because young generations now tend to have similar stylistic intuitions about the case-marked variety, and, other things being equal, they prefer the caseless variety *in general*.

3.4 1SG and 2SG possessive nouns phrase objects

To be able to assess the distribution of accusative case on possessive noun phrases, I have selected 5 nouns that occur frequently enough as possessums in each of the 5 corpora. These nouns are as follows: *ház* ‘house’, *hit* ‘faith’, *kéz* ‘hand’, *szív* ‘heart’ and the inalienably possessed noun *fia* ‘someone’s son’. When these act as the possessum of possessive noun phrase objects, their possessor is frequently co-construed with the subject argument of the verb. Thus, they provide for a direct and natural comparison with reflexives. (21) and (22), both from the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus, illustrate the construction and pertinent variation in the spellout of accusative case in Modern Hungarian.

- (21) *Vedd le rólam a kez-ed!*
 take.IMP.SG down from.1SG the hand-POSS.2SG
 ‘Take your hands off me.’
- (22) *Vedd le a kez-ed-et a füledről.*
 take.IMP.SG down the hand-POSS.2SG-ACC the ear.POSS.2SG.from
 ‘Take your hands off your ears.’

(21) contains the caseless object possessive *kezed* ‘your hand’, and the same phrase occurs with overt accusative case in (22): *kez-ed-et* ‘your hand-ACC’.

¹⁴ The subcorpus of the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus that I have queried on reflexives, the spoken language subcorpus, contains mostly the written texts of dialogue-based radio programmes, where participants typically use a slightly conservative spoken register.

The corpus search targeted such examples, and the results are summarized in Figure 3 below.

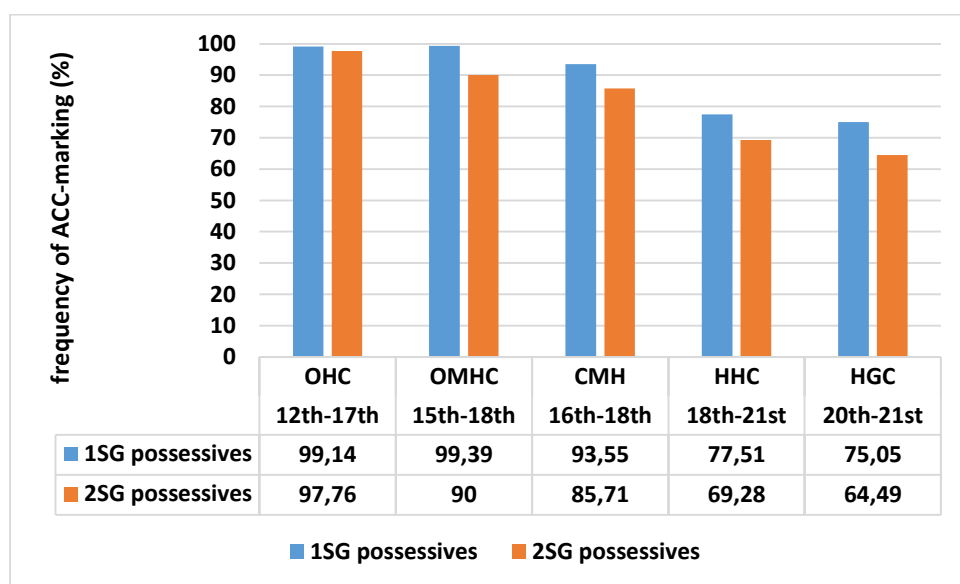


Figure 3. The relative frequency of ACC-marked forms among 1SG and 2SG possessive noun phrase objects in 5 corpora

Like in Figures 1 and 2, here too we see a gradual decrease in the frequency of accusative case. But while accusative case is either avoided in Modern Hungarian (1SG and 2SG personal pronouns), or is gradually becoming a marked option (1SG and 2SG reflexives), it still seems to be a slightly preferred option in the case of possessive noun phrase objects on the whole. Corpus data thus confirm both the judgements reported in the literature and the intuitions of native speakers that I have consulted.

3.5 Diachronic changes: A summary overview

Figure 4 provides an overview of the historical changes that we have described in Subsections 3.2–4. The data points are simply the arithmetic means of the 1SG and 2SG frequencies quoted in Figures 1–3. Comparing the 5 corpora gives us a rough estimate of the respective trendlines from the earliest documented historical period of Hungarian (OHC) to Modern Hungarian (HGC).

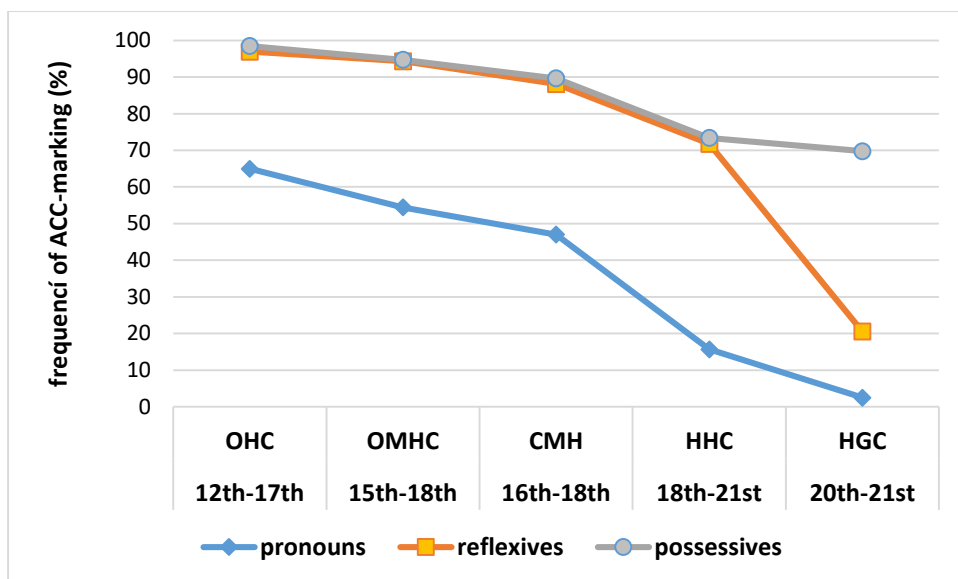


Figure 4. The diachronic decline of ACC-marking in the 1SG and 2SG possessive domain

Accusative case marking in what I call here the 1SG and 2SG possessive domain was at its peak in the Old Hungarian period, and it has been gradually decreasing in frequency since then. But while this drop is relatively moderate in the case of possessive noun phrases, reflexives and object pronouns show a sharper decline, especially in the last couple of centuries. What we see in Figure 4 confirms our hypothesis concerning the decrease of accusative case use on grammaticalized possessive structures *relative* to the degree of grammaticalization. The object pronouns, which had already lost much of their syntactically active possessive structure by the Old Hungarian period, were only mildly accusative preferring in that age. By now, they have practically lost their accusative case. The primary reflexive, which used to be a less grammaticalized possessive structure in Old Hungarian than it is now, patterned with possessive noun phrases until the Middle Hungarian period; but then it started to go on its own way and it now occurs in its caseless variety more frequently. This reflects the strongly grammaticalized nature of this reflexive in the synchronic stage.

É. Kiss & Mus (2022) treat instances of no accusative use on syntactic objects in the synchronic system as fossilized relics of the Proto-Hungarian past. Our findings here are thus surprising. Why was accusative marking at its peak in Old Hungarian, and why is there a gradual drop in accusative use in the possessive domain after this period?

Most of the general spread of accusative case happened in the Proto-Hungarian period, and by the end of the Old Hungarian era (early 16th century), the system of accusative marking was complete – with the exception of smaller pockets of the language, most prominently the possessive domain that we study here. Note that Hungarian is unlike its Indo-European neighbours (or Latin, for that matter) in not having separate declension classes and instances of case-syncretism on lexical nouns or pronouns. A single accusative case suffix (-*Vt*) is used across the board. Though language contact in the early Old Hungarian period might have contributed to an overall spread of accusative case even to the 1SG and 2SG possessive domain, this extra stretch of accusative use appears to be an internal development. It is reasonable to assume that native speakers of the age simply overused a device that was still relatively new.

But even then, object personal pronouns never had to be augmented with the accusative case suffix in an obligatory manner, as we have seen. Thus, these pronouns may have contributed to the gradual decline of accusative use in this domain *as an analogical source*, and, ever since

the Old Hungarian period, the language seems to have been going back to the pre-Old Hungarian state that É. Kiss’s diachronic model describes. One factor that may have facilitated or fuelled this change is the shift from SOV to SVO, also happening in the Old Hungarian period (see É. Kiss 2023). We know independently that there is a universal positive correlation between SOV and the presence of case marking, but SVO correlates with case marking negatively (see Simonenko 2023 for a recent overview). And while Hungarian is still not consistently SVO, pertinent syntactic changes have resulted in a system where the lack of overt accusative case marking is a better fit. Or, to be more precise, it is a better fit as far as the empirical domain we study here is concerned.

Irrespective of how and why the changes summarized in Figure 4 happened, the trend of losing accusative case on 1SG and 2SG possessives, reflexives and object pronouns is robust. As I have argued above, the frequency of accusative use inversely correlates with the advance of the grammaticalization of the possessive structure of object pronouns and reflexives, as is expected given the exaptation account that É. Kiss & Mus (2022) propose. What is also evident from the diachronic data is that this process of function change has gone through for pronouns, and it is still in progress among reflexives. The next section focuses on the finer distribution of accusative case in the reflexive domain.

4. Reflexives and accusative case in contemporary Hungarian

4.1 *Önmagam* ‘myself’ and accusative case in contemporary Hungarian

We have seen that the diachronic development of the primary reflexives *magam* ‘myself’ and *magad* ‘yourself’ is characterized by a gradual decline in accusative case use in object positions. This decline came to be a more pronounced drop towards the end of the Middle Hungarian period (18th century) so that 1SG and 2SG primary reflexive objects are more likely to occur without an overt accusative case marker in the synchronic system. I have also argued that the intensity of accusative drop correlates with the degree of grammaticalization that the original possessive structure of the reflexive has gone through. What we expect then at the synchronic stage is that if there is variation among reflexive forms in terms of the degree of grammaticalization, then there will be concomitant variation in the frequency of accusative case use.

The predictions concerning the grammar of the complex reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’ are straightforward. I have argued in 2.2 that *önmagam* still has strong possessive features in contemporary Hungarian, in contrast to *magam*, which is weakened in this respect. We thus expect *önmagam* to be less accusative-avoiding in object positions than *magam*. Native speakers that I have consulted, especially the younger generations, confirm this intuition. Consider the following minimal pair for illustration.

- (23) a. *Nem látod magad(-at) a tükörben.* preferred: *magad*
 not see.2SG yourself-ACC the mirror.in
 ‘You cannot see yourself in the mirror.’
- b. *Nem látod ön-magad(-at) a tükörben.* preferred: *önmagadat*
 not see.2SG self-yourself-ACC the mirror.in
 ‘You cannot see yourself in the mirror.’

Both the caseless and the case-marked variants are grammatical in both sentences, but other things being equal, speakers prefer the caseless *magad* ‘yourself’ in (23a), and they prefer the case-marked *önmagadat* ‘yourself’ in (23b). The default interpretation of the two sentences is also different. (23a) is normally about the inability to see one’s image in the mirror. For many, (23b) asserts that the physical image of the self is observed, but what the listener sees is not the

expected representation of the self. In other words, (23b) implicates a sort of referential differentiation between the true self and a slightly dissimilar conceptualization of it, along the lines that we have discussed in 2.2.

It is important to emphasize that the typical judgements concerning the form and the interpretation of the two reflexives in (23) display a pattern of trend-like preferences, rather than absolute differences in grammaticality. To confirm intuitions concerning trends in accusative case use, I searched the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus, targeting the 1SG and 2SG forms of the two reflexives, and possessive noun phrases with 1SG and 2SG possessors. The search was restricted to selected subcorpora of the HGC, and Figure 5 provides a summary of the results (see the Appendix for the query details).

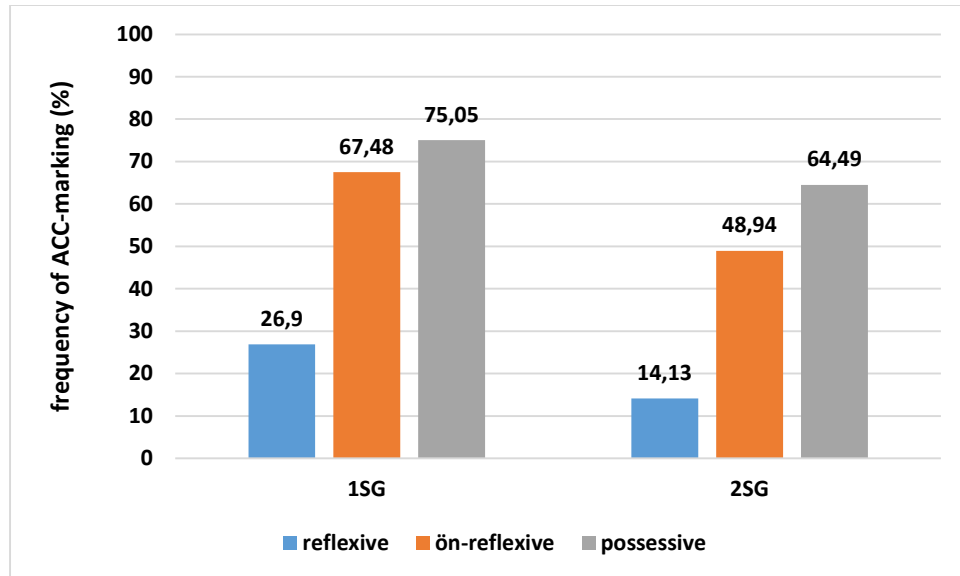


Figure 5. 1SG and 2SG reflexives and possessive noun phrases qua objects in the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus

As is evident, *önmagam* is quite unlike the primary reflexive, and the distribution of its accusative-marked and caseless variants is much closer to the distribution that we see in the case of possessive noun phrases. These data therefore confirm our hypothesis, since accusative spellout is more frequent on the less grammaticalized reflexive *önmaga*. The sharp, and otherwise surprising, contrast between the two types of reflexives is not accidental.

4.2 *Magam* ‘myself’ and *magamat* ‘myself’ qua objects in contemporary Hungarian

We have noted in subsection 3.3 that accusative drop first appeared on the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ in the Middle Hungarian period, dominantly in configurations where the reflexive is the object of an intrinsically reflexive predicate. I repeat (20) as (24) for illustration.

- (24) *Emészttem magam, de haszontalan.* (OMHC, 1709)
 digest.1SG myself but futilely
 ‘I worry myself to death, but to no avail.’

If, as I argue here, accusative drop is in fact a process of exaptation which involves the repurposing of the possessive morphology, then the emergence of the caseless version of the primary reflexive heralds the arrival of a strongly grammaticalized reflexive form. And while the caseless version has become the preferred option in contemporary Hungarian, it is still in

competition with the case-marked form. It is plausible to assume that this variation is not *entirely* free.

I make the relatively straightforward assumption that if a reflexive has an active possessive structure, then that structure has to be interpreted. It can be evoked in cases of referential differentiation (see (23b) above), or when the reflexive acts as a referential expression. Exempt reflexives are often referential in this sense, especially if they do not have a linguistic antecedent. Accusative case on reflexives is therefore not only an indicator of an active possessive structure, but also of the relative semantic independence of the reflexive.

At this point, it is worth pointing out that the factors that influence the distribution of the caseless and the case-marked variants of the primary reflexive in Hungarian may contribute to a system in other languages where the choice between different reflexive forms is more definitive. Dutch is one such language. Intrinsically reflexive predicates require the reflexive *zich* in third person (25). Following Reinhart & Reuland (1993), I gloss it as a SE-anaphor, short for *simplex anaphor*. The default reflexive for cases of local binding is *zichzelf* elsewhere (26). The two types of reflexives are in complementary distribution in the contexts represented by (25) and (26), and neither shows number and gender distinctions. A third type of reflexive, *hemzelf* ‘himself’ is used as an exempt anaphor, which Anagnostopoulou & Everaert (1999) claim to occur mostly in logophoric contexts (27).

- (25) Dutch, Reinhart & Reuland (1993: 691)
Lucie gedroeg zich goed.
 Lucie behaved SE well
 ‘Lucie behaved herself well.’
- (26) Dutch, Reinhart & Reuland (1993: 706)
Willem bewondert zichzelf.
 Willem admires SE.self
 ‘Willem admires himself.’
- (27) Dutch, Anagnostopoulou & Everaert (1999: 116)
Hij koopt twee tickets voor zijn vriendin en hemzelf.
 he buys two tickets for his girlfriend and him.self
 ‘He buys two tickets for his girlfriend and himself.’

English has a single type of reflexive for each of these three functions. The Hungarian primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ is also grammatical across this domain, but the distribution of accusative case on 1SG and 2SG forms manifests what Bresnan (2016) describes as “statistical shadows” of the hard constraints that govern the choice of the three reflexive types in Dutch. In particular, the accusative-marked variant is overrepresented in contexts of exempt anaphora, and the caseless variant dominates qua the object of intrinsically reflexive predicates. I have conducted a pilot study in the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus to substantiate this claim.

The corpus examples in (28) represent configurations of exempt anaphora. The logophoric reflexive has no linguistic antecedent in (28a), and thus it has to be referential. (28b) contains a reflexive that is one conjunct of a coordinate object, and the reflexive object is focused in (28c). Both of these latter configurations include cases of exempt anaphora in the Reflexivity framework of Reinhart & Reuland (1993).

- (28) a. *A többség, magam-at is beleértve, bízik a sikerben.*
 the majority myself-ACC too included trust.3SG the success.in
 ‘The majority, myself included, is confident about success.’

- b. *Felajánlom magam-at és mindenem-et.*
 offer.DEFOBJ.1SG myself-ACC and everything.POSS.1SG-ACC
 ‘I offer myself and my everything.’
- c. *Csak magad-at okolhatod.*
 only yourself-ACC blame.POS.DEFOBJ.2SG
 ‘You can only blame yourself.’

Each example in (28) contains an accusative-marked reflexive. I conducted a query on the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus that targeted these constructions, including word order variants of (28a) and (28c). The results of this corpus search are summarized in Table 4 below.

reflexive constructions	English translation	<i>magamat</i>	<i>magam</i>	<i>magadat</i>	<i>magad</i>
		myself.ACC	myself	yourself.ACC	yourself
<i>beleértve X</i>	‘including X’	44	4	0	0
<i>X is beleértve</i>	‘X too included’	172	0	3	0
<i>csak X okol</i>	‘only X blame. [lemma]’	28	1	15	0
<i>N.ACC és X</i>	‘N.ACC and X’	80	8	9	0
<i>X és N.ACC</i>	‘X and N.ACC’	49	20	22	14
sum of occurrences		373	33	49	14
proportion of accusative-marked forms		91,87%		77,78%	

Table 4. Exempt uses of object 1SG and 2SG primary reflexives in the HGC

Though this is only a probe into a much more complex data set, the results indicate a very strong preference for accusative spellout in these configurations, in sharp contrast with the overall low frequency of accusative case on the primary reflexive (see Figure 5).

The frequency of accusative use is expected to be below average if the verb is intrinsically reflexive. This is so because the reflexive is a mere syntactic formative here, and there is thus no trigger to invoke the less grammaticalized possessive structure which we associate with the case-marked form, for the simple reason that there is no need for a structure that can be interpreted. The following two examples from the Hungarian Gigaword Corpus represent such contexts.

- (29) a. *Nem szóltam semmit, csak szégyelltem magam.*
 not said.1SG nothing only shame.PAST.DEFOBJ.1SG myself
 ‘I didn’t say anything, I was just ashamed of myself.’
- b. *Meggondoltad magad, azért mondod.*
 PRT.thought.DEFOBJ.2SG yourself that.for say.DEFOBJ.2SG
 ‘You have changed your mind, that is why you say this.’

Table 5 gives a summary of a corpus query in which I searched for 5 such verb lemmas taking 1SG and 2SG primary reflexive objects. A reflexive object is either obligatory for these verbs (as for *elnevet* ‘burst out laughing’), or it is a non-obligatory, but frequent option (*szégyell* ‘be ashamed of’).

intrinsically reflexive verbs	English translation	<i>magamat</i>	<i>magam</i>	<i>magadat</i>	<i>magad</i>
		myself.acc	myself	yourself.acc	yourself
<i>elnevet X</i>	‘burst out laughing’	37	295	0	14
<i>meggondol X</i>	‘change one’s mind’	16	339	6	150
<i>szégyell X</i>	‘be ashamed of oneself’	162	1875	27	737
<i>elhatárol X</i>	‘distance oneself’	11	72	4	15
<i>elkötelez X</i>	‘commit oneself’	13	154	9	10
sum		239	2735	46	926
proportion of accusative-marked forms		8,04%		4,73%	

Table 5. 1SG and 2SG primary reflexives by intrinsically reflexive verbs in the HGC

The emerging picture is quite the opposite of what we see in Table 4: accusative case is rarely used on the reflexive here.

The choice between the accusative-marked and the caseless reflexive is thus not entirely arbitrary in 1SG and 2SG, and their distribution weakly approximates the pattern in which the Dutch reflexives carve up the grammatical space they occupy. In particular, the accusative-marked variant is the dominant choice in contexts where *hemzelf* occurs in Dutch, and the caseless variant is more likely to be used elsewhere, especially in object positions where *zich* occurs in Dutch. We may in fact make the assumption that caseless *magam* ‘myself’ and *magad* ‘yourself’ qua objects are similar to Dutch *zich* in not being truly complex reflexive anaphors any more, or at least not necessarily. Lehmann (2015 [1982]: 49), who does not discuss the accusative facts we have surveyed here, essentially takes this position when he suggests that a change may be underway for the Hungarian reflexive, as it will possibly become a *simplex reflexive* (a *reflexive pronoun* in his terminology).

The transitive minimal pair in (30) illustrates the effects that we have discussed here. (30a) contains the caseless variant *magam*, whereas the reflexive is dressed with accusative case in (30b).

- (30) a. *Jól le-ittam magam.*
 well down-drunk.DEFOBJ.1SG myself
 preferred reading: ‘I got quite drunk/I drank myself blind.’
- b. *Jól le-ittam magam-at.*
 well down-drunk.DEFOBJ.1SG myself-ACC
 preferred reading: ‘I poured some drink over me.’

The preferred or, for many speakers the only, reading of (30a) is idiomatic. The predicate is intrinsically reflexive on this reading, just like in the case of the English *I drank myself blind*, where *myself* cannot be contrasted with or replaced by a noun phrase or a pronoun. *Magam* is thus a fake object reflexive here, void of substantial semantic contribution. In contrast, many speakers interpret (30b) as a regular transitive construction, where the reflexive stands for the clothes that the speaker is wearing, or their body in general. In fact, here the reflexive can be replaced by a noun phrase referring to the target area. This is the interpretation that requires a genuine reflexive, a form which licenses a referential shift from the speaker to the clothes they wear, for example.

If what I claim here is on the right track, then the two reflexive object variants in (30) identify two distinct stages of the grammaticalization process. The caseless object *magam* has the most grammaticalized possessive structure among reflexives, but the case-marked

magamat has retained at least a weakly active possessive structure. There might be substantial variation among speakers concerning pertinent judgements, but, arguably, variation in the spellout of accusative case on the primary reflexive has become weakly functional in the synchronic stage of the language. That such factorization may occur is a natural consequence of the grammaticalization account that I have proposed in this paper.

5. Conclusions

Hungarian reflexives, as well as 1SG and 2SG object pronouns have possessive morphology. This is less surprising for reflexives, whose historical source is a possessive structure with a lexical possessum with the reconstructed meaning ‘body’. Such a diachrony is frequent for reflexives cross-linguistically, and É. Kiss & Mus (2022) point out that it is a characteristic feature of Ugric and Samoyedic languages that they may preserve the original possessive morphology on personal pronouns in the series of historical changes which transform reflexives into neutral pronouns eventually. They argue that these changes are cyclic in nature, and they involve the repurposing of the original possessive morphology as an accusative marker.

I have argued in this paper that understanding this diachrony is a useful instrument in a more adequate description of the synchronic system of reflexives and object pronouns in Hungarian. The synchronic data that we have surveyed represent different stages of the grammaticalization of the possessive structure of these elements, all at the same contemporary state of the language. The complex reflexive *önmagam* ‘myself’ has the most active possessive features, whereas the primary reflexive *magam* ‘myself’ is more strongly grammaticalized. 1SG and 2SG object pronouns are at the end of this change, displaying no possessive properties beyond their surface morphology in standard Hungarian.

This paper is the first comprehensive attempt at describing the diachrony and the synchrony of accusative drop in this domain. Corpus data show that accusative use was more dominant in the Old Hungarian period across the board among possessive noun phrases, reflexives, and 1SG and 2SG object pronouns; but historical data also show that accusative marking has clearly been on the decline since then. Reflexives and 1SG and 2SG object pronouns have been losing their accusative case faster than possessive noun phrases, which I have interpreted as a reflex of grammaticalization in this specific context. I have also argued that accusative drop on reflexives is a functional feature of contemporary Hungarian: accusative spellout is a harmonic fit for semantically contentful interpretations, whereas the caseless variety is used elsewhere, especially when the reflexive is a mere syntactic formative by intrinsically reflexive verbs.

The loss of accusative case and the loss of the active possessive structure are inherently tied up. Following É. Kiss & Mus (2022), I have regarded accusative drop as an instance of exaptation in a specific grammatical context: when the possessive morphology loses its original function, it is repurposed as an accusative marker. In a sense, Modern Hungarian is closer to the pre-Old Hungarian stage of the language, when accusative case marking was still on the rise. The observed diachronic changes concerning the use of accusative case in the possessive domain thus conceivably show a rise-and-fall pattern.

This paper is a first probe into this data set, and as such, it leaves ample room for further investigations into this domain. I have not discussed plural possessives and reflexives, where accusative drop is a more constrained option for most speakers. If the decline of accusative case marking continues, then accusative drop may become a more general option in the plural, too, especially for younger generations. Furthermore, 2SG forms on the whole appear to be less accusative-preferring than 1SG forms, at least this is what the corpus data I have quoted here show. I have abstracted over this difference in this paper, and it is a question for future research whether this difference is significant enough to merit a differential treatment in grammar. Finally, accusative drop might be sensitive to several factors which I have not discussed here:

to the position of the object (pre-verbal vs post-verbal), to its discourse function in the preverbal field, and possibly even to extra-linguistic factors, such as the speech frequency or the phonological weight of the possessum in the case of possessive noun phrases. I believe nevertheless that further investigations will only provide further evidence for those trends and effects that I have identified in this paper as the major characteristics of accusative drop.

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I. Appendix

I.1 The corpora used in this study: References

Old Hungarian Corpus (OHC)

<http://oldhungariancorpus.nytud.hu/>

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The Old and Middle Hungarian Corpus of Informal Language Use (OMHC)

<https://tmk.nytud.hu/>

- Novák, Attila, Katalin Gugán, Mónika Varga & Adrienne Dömötör. 2018. Creation of an annotated corpus of Old and Middle Hungarian court records and private correspondence. *Language Resources and Evaluation* 52. 1–28. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10579-017-9393-8>
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Corpus of Middle Hungarian Memoires and Dramas (CMH)

<https://ked.nytud.hu/>

- Gugán, Katalin, Enikő Bácsi, Adrienne Dömötör, László Horváth, Zsuzsanna Mohay, Mónika Varga & Bálint Sass. 2023. Középmagyar emlékirat- és drámakorpusz. [Corpus of Middle Hungarian Memoires and Dramas.]

Hungarian Historical Corpus (HHC)
<https://clara.nytud.hu/mtsz/>

Hungarian Gigaword Corpus v2.0.5 (HGC)
<https://clara.nytud.hu/mnsz2-dev/>

Oravecz, Csaba, Tamás Váradi & Bálint Sass. 2014. The Hungarian Gigaword Corpus. In *Proceedings of the Ninth International Conference on Language Resources and Evaluation (LREC'14)*, 1719–1723. Reykjavik, Iceland: European Language Resources Association (ELRA).

I.2 The corpus queries: Raw frequency data

The tables below give an overview of the raw frequency data resulting from the corpus queries.

- I add the names of the diagrams that reference these data in the main text.
- I did the searches on the normalized forms in the case of the three historical corpora OHC, OMHC and CMH. (This abstracts over spelling differences, some of which reflect differences in pronunciation. *Magamat* ‘myself.ACC’, for example, sometimes occurs as *magomat*.)
- For reflexives and possessives, the search had to be restricted to subcorpora of HHC and HGC. If this was the case, then the relevant identifiers are added in the last column. The absence of this specification means that the whole corpus was searched.
- The procedure for restriction to subcorpus was as follows: I searched for roughly 1000 occurrences of the target caseless form, and manually selected the data where this form acts as the object of the clause. These cc. 1000 sentences defined the subcorpus (via the document identifiers) that was searched for the accusative-marked variety of the search target. Since both the –ACC and the +ACC searches were performed on the same (sub)corpus, the frequency results are comparable.
- As described in the main text, the corpus study of possessives was restricted to stems *ház* ‘house’, *hit* ‘faith’, *kéz* ‘hand’, *szív* ‘heart’ and the inalienably possessed noun *fia* ‘someone’s son’.

	1SG		2SG	
	+ACC	-ACC	+ACC	-ACC
	<i>engemet</i>	<i>engem</i>	<i>tégedet</i>	<i>téged</i>
OHC	2070	662	789	668
OMHC	363	312	60	49
CMH	106	96	22	31
HHC	1633	8787	558	3013
HGC	4307	135183	914	50010

Table I. 1SG and 2SG object pronouns with and without accusative case
(→ Figures 1, 4)

	+ACC	-ACC		SUBCORPUS
	object		non-object	
	<i>magamat</i>	<i>magam</i>	<i>magam</i>	
OHC	134	2	51	
OMHC	441	24	865	
CMH	52	4	156	
HHC	502	116	597	only texts between 1800-1850
HGC	149	405	711	spoken language subcorpus, doc#2597-2602,

Table II. 1SG primary reflexives with and without accusative case
(→ Figures 2, 4, 5)

	+ACC	-ACC		SUBCORPUS
	object		non-object	
	<i>magadat</i>	<i>magad</i>	<i>magad</i>	
OHC	223	11	31	
OMHC	106	7	178	
CMH	15	3	28	
HHC	180	109	245	only texts between 1800-1850
HGC	64	389	213	spoken language subcorpus

Table III. 2SG primary reflexives with and without accusative case
(→ Figures 2, 4, 5)

	+ACC	-ACC		SUBCORPUS
	object		non-object	
	N.POSS.1SG.ACC	N.POSS.1SG	N.POSS.1SG	
OHC	115	1	391	
OMHC	162	1	3579	
CMH	29	2	47	
HHC	1296	376	5334	
HGC	1194	397	4614	doc#1-275~2245

Table IV. 1SG possessives with and without accusative case
(→ Figures 3, 4, 5)

	+ACC	-ACC		SUBCORPUS
	object		non-object	
	N.POSS.2SG.ACC	N.POSS.2SG	N.POSS.2SG	
OHC	131	3	238	
OMHC	18	2	39	
CMH	6	1	11	
HHC	397	176	1052	
HGC	1008	555	4178	doc#1-981~2950

Table V. 2SG possessives with and without accusative case
(→ Figures 3, 4, 5)

	+ACC	-ACC		SUBCORPUS
	object		non-object	
1sg	<i>önmagamat</i>	<i>önmagam</i>	<i>önmagam</i>	
	473	228	771	doc#1-2136
2sg	<i>önmagadat</i>	<i>önmagad</i>	<i>önmagad</i>	
	392	409	600	doc#1-2669

Table VI. 1SG and 2SG complex reflexives with and without accusative case
(→ Figure 5)

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